

ALDABRA GIANT TORTOISE

Aldabrachelys gigantea

The last remaining species of giant tortoise on islands in the Indian Ocean, the Aldabra giant tortoise can weigh over 300 kg (660 lb). Though resident on three islets of the Aldabra atoll, over 90 per cent of the tortoises live on Grande-Terre – the largest islet by far – despite the scarcity of water and inadequate supply of vegetation. Poor conditions there have inhibited the growth of individual tortoises, with many not reaching sexual maturity. However, they are highly sociable, more so than the larger tortoises on other islets. Males are larger than females, but courtship is a gentle affair. Their eggs are buried underground, and hatch in the rainy season. The whole population is vulnerable to natural disasters and rising sea levels.

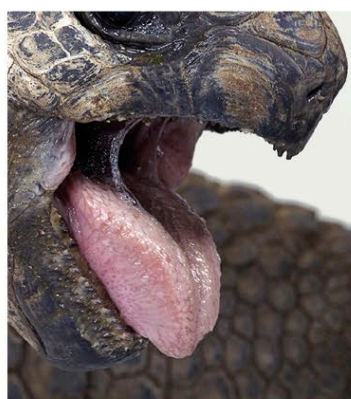


SIZE 1.2 m (4 ft)
HABITAT Grassy areas
DISTRIBUTION Aldabra, Indian Ocean
DIET Vegetation



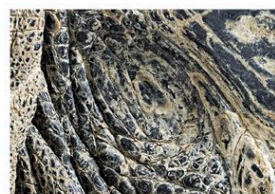
^ LEATHERY VISAGE

The skin is tough, leathery, and – depending on islet – either grey or brown. The skin is creased into folds around the neck. If it senses danger, the tortoise pulls its head back inside its shell.



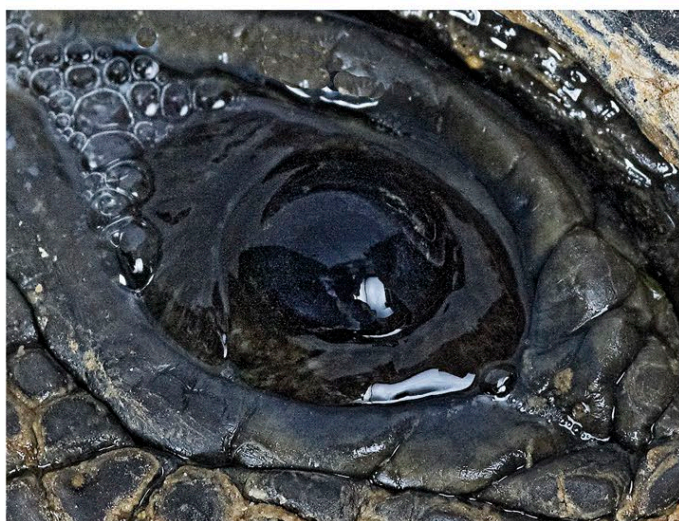
< HORNY BEAK

The tortoise's large mouth contains no teeth. It cuts vegetation with its sharp, horny beak, takes it into the mouth with its tongue, and swallows it whole.



< EAR

Tortoises have no external ear flap; so the eardrum is situated in a hollow.



< EYE

The eye is relatively large and has a well-developed eyelid. Tortoises can see in colour, particularly in the red and yellow parts of the spectrum; this probably helps them to find colourful fruit.



^ FORELEG

The front limbs are cylindrical in shape, and longer than the hind limbs. This allows the tortoise to raise its body well above the ground as it walks. The legs are covered in large, tough scales.



< DIGGING CLAWS

Tortoises have sturdy, elephant-like hind limbs, with five claws on each foot. Females have larger claws than males, which they use when excavating a nesting site.



< TAIL

The giant tortoise has a short tail, and can tuck it to one side under the back of the carapace. Males have longer tails than females.

horny scales cover the front and hind limbs

hind limbs are elephantine, with strong claws